

Design a story, then defend it

Create original key art for a fictional short film intended for a school or community screening. You are the designer: invent the premise, choose a specific audience and make an image that promises that story. No film production or film viewing is required.

Your minimum product is one original poster with purposeful image manipulation and editable text. Combine at least two permitted visual sources, or a photograph and your own constructed shapes. Keep a meaningful visibility mask and a purposeful adjustment layer. Complexity is optional; decisions and evidence matter.

Print study master: 2550 × 3300 pixels, equivalent to 8.5 × 11 inches at 300 ppi. Maintain the layered PSD. Export a flattened PNG for viewing. Keep RGB unless the teacher specifies a verified printer/profile workflow; ask for a school-printer proof before treating the export as press-ready.

Deliver: concise proposal; credited mood board; three different thumbnails; two colour/type treatments; layered PSD and PNG; two real viewer responses; one documented revision; source/AI log; three-decision defence and final reflection.

Deadline: the date agreed with the teacher and recorded in your proposal. Use the teacher-assigned classroom submission route. This package does not submit to a Form or dashboard.

Your one-page proposal

Working title and one-sentence premise: _____

Audience and viewing context: _____

The first message/emotion I want a viewer to understand: _____

Product and required dimensions: _____

My specific goal: By [teacher-agreed date], I will create [product] for [audience/context], using [taught controls], and demonstrate [observable communication result].

Three ideas I will compare; why they differ: _____

Two real references and what I can learn from each: _____

My success check: At the intended viewing size, I will ask two peers what they noticed first and what premise they inferred; I will compare their actual responses with my intent.

Permitted production sources, technical risk and fallback: _____

Checkpoint dates: plan _____ / editable first version _____ / revised handoff _____

Two or three primary targets, with visible evidence: 1.1 manipulation; 1.2 image context; 1.3 procedures; 1.4 design principles; 1.5 communication. Select what your evidence actually demonstrates.

Teacher feasibility check / agreed deadline: _____

Lab 1 — Research and plan (25–35 minutes)

After the design teaching, choose a premise that can be represented safely and with sources you may use. In a few sentences describe the audience, message and viewing encounter. Do not start with an effect you want to copy.

Compare the Saul Bass poster with the current BILLIE identity in Deck 1. Record maker, date, source, one visible design choice, a sourced contextual fact and a possible interpretation. The A24 Moonlight image is a film still, not a release poster. You may use a teacher-approved alternative if a theme is unsuitable.

Open <https://excalidraw.com> in a browser. Use its image tool to insert a small number of credited study references. Add text naming each reference and a reason. Add five labelled colour-role samples and title/detail type-role examples. Separate study references from production assets.

Draw three small composition thumbnails: change the principal arrangement or storytelling device, rather than moving one item. Compare image-led, symbol-led and type-led directions. Select one against the audience, communication and feasible production criteria; explain one rejected alternative.

Use the Excalidraw menu to save the editable scene as an .excalidraw file. Export a PNG for viewing. Reopen the scene and check that text and shapes remain editable. If the site is blocked, make the same annotated plan on paper or in an existing school-approved browser tool.

Success: a usable proposal, credited direction board, distinct alternatives and a reasoned selection. A collection of attractive pictures alone is incomplete.

Lab 2 — Colour and type decisions (15–20 minutes)

Predict the effect of two colour/type treatments for the same selected thumbnail. Keep the message and arrangement comparable; change a deliberate relationship. Name the wheel model when calling a relationship complementary or analogous.

Use Adobe Color or your own permitted sample image to propose five colours. Record HEX values and dominant/support/accent/background/text roles. Test actual text/background pairs; a harmonious palette does not guarantee legibility.

Photoshop documented manual route: choose the foreground colour, enter its HEX value, then open Window → Swatches and use New Swatch. Name the colour by role and repeat for the remaining colours. Adobe documents CSS/HTML/SVG import via the Swatches menu; the downloadable CSS is a sample, and native CSS import is not verified in this build. Use manual addition if that option is absent; do not replace existing collections.

Select the Type layer and the relevant text. In Character controls, test size, leading and tracking. Kerning affects a pair; tracking affects a range; leading is baseline-to-baseline distance. Inspect at the intended viewing size, then retain editable Type layers.

Use two short written observations to choose one treatment. Explain a readable hierarchy and one trade-off. Submit the two views and your decision; the worked sample palette is not a required answer.

Lab 3 — A recoverable composite (25–40 minutes)

Work in a practice copy using your own permitted sources. Place and name the sources; compare scale, perspective and plausible light before adding effects. Save a layered PSD.

Documented masking route: select the image layer → Select → Subject → inspect the selection → add a layer mask. Inspect at a close view and at the intended viewing size. Select the mask thumbnail before using a soft brush: black hides, white reveals, grey partially reveals.

Documented tonal route: Layer → New Adjustment Layer → Curves. Change a relevant tonal relationship and toggle the adjustment for comparison. For a subject-only change, use Layer → Create Clipping Mask on the adjustment above the intended base layer; refine with its own mask where appropriate.

Name one visible inconsistency. Identify its likely control, change that control recoverably and compare before/after at the same view. Inspect mask edges, neutral areas, highlights and whether the background changed unexpectedly.

Deck 2 contains conceptual diagrams and constructed result states, plus genuine controls in Deck 1. These are not a verified screenshot for every software action. Teacher demonstration or the documented Adobe reference is needed when a route is unfamiliar; school-version cold-run remains pending.

Success: show the relevant mask and adjustment, demonstrate one visible repair and explain why it works. Extra particles, rays and glow are optional.

Produce, test, revise and hand off

Build the selected direction in your own PSD. Artboards are useful when comparing layouts, but one defined canvas is sufficient for the required poster. A mood board sets direction; a thumbnail explores composition; an artboard develops a layout.

For artboards, Adobe documents the Artboard tool grouped with Move, and creating/naming artboards in an existing document. Check the selected board's actual width/height in Properties. The captured older practice setting is not this project's final dimension. Use 2550 × 3300 for this print study. An optional 1080 × 1350 screen version requires reflow rather than stretching.

Show the first version to two peers at its intended size. Without explaining the premise first, ask: What did you notice first? What story/message did you infer? Which essential detail was difficult to read? Record their actual responses without names. Two peers provide limited formative evidence, not a representative audience study.

Choose one mismatch with your intent. State your prediction, revise a relevant relationship, show before/after and say whether the result improved. Keep a remaining limitation visible.

Independent checkpoint: the teacher supplies one change using taught design or technical concepts. Predict the consequence, make your own revision, then defend it with the relevant source controls. A new tutorial recipe is not supplied for this checkpoint.

File check: reopen the PSD and viewing PNG; verify dimensions, visible result, editable text, named layers/masks and credit log. Package them with proposal, alternatives, viewer test, revision and defence. File naming: MM12_S04_[working-title]_[source/view/plan/defence]_v01; replace bracketed labels with your own words.

Final reflection (three short responses): What did testing change? Which control/decision can you now explain independently? What would you investigate next? Supports used are recorded separately from achievement.

Individual knowledge check and retrieval

Complete after teaching, without copying a model response. Sketches and a brief oral explanation are acceptable evidence with teacher agreement.

1. Select a fresh teacher-provided advertisement or poster. Identify first and second reading priorities and explain two visible features that establish them.
2. Sketch a named colour-wheel relationship. Distinguish hue from value, and explain why a palette relationship does not guarantee text readability.
3. Explain the difference between kerning, tracking and leading. Name which one you would inspect for a pair, a word and two lines.
4. Explain selection versus mask, and clipping versus an adjustment mask. Show a relevant control in your practice file and its visible consequence.
5. Compare a historical and a current reference: one visible observation, one sourced contextual fact and one possible emotional interpretation. Distinguish fact from inference.
6. Explain how your mood board, thumbnails and production layout answer different planning questions.

After feedback, correct an uncertain concept and apply it to a different image. Next class retrieve three concepts without notes; after a longer delay critique an unfamiliar layout. A confidence rating or completed tutorial is not an achievement grade.

Project rubric — evidence descriptors

Unweighted descriptor guide; existing grading policy is unchanged. Missing evidence = insufficient evidence.

Communication

Beginning: The premise, audience and viewing context are vague or contradict the image.

Developing: Some story or audience cues are visible; priorities remain unclear.

Secure: The image communicates a clear premise with justified reading priorities at the intended view.

Extending: Choices anticipate competing interpretations and viewing constraints; tests support purposeful refinements.

Design and typography

Beginning: Relationships are accidental or key text is difficult to read.

Developing: Some deliberate hierarchy, colour and type choices; inconsistencies reduce meaning.

Secure: Hierarchy, contrast, composition, colour roles and editable typography work coherently for the brief.

Extending: Controlled alternatives and careful refinements improve communication; exceptions are justified with evidence.

Recoverable technique

Beginning: Edits cannot be inspected or serious edge/light faults undermine the image.

Developing: Relevant masks/adjustments are present; some faults remain or controls are hard to locate.

Secure: Named layers, masks and adjustments enable revision; edges, light and tone are coherent at the required view.

Extending: Precise diagnosis and controlled refinements handle difficult relationships while preserving the source.

Research and context

Beginning: References are uncredited or described only as likes/dislikes.

Developing: Sources are recorded; visual observations or historical/cultural context are partial.

Secure: Two genuine references are analysed through visible form and sourced context; production sources and AI use are documented.

Extending: Comparison weighs plausible alternative readings and limitations; research informs a distinctive choice without copying.

Testing and revision

Beginning: No usable test or revision evidence.

Developing: A response is recorded, but its connection to a change is weak.

Secure: Actual viewer responses lead to a targeted revision; before/after evidence evaluates its effect.

Extending: The student evaluates conflicting feedback, checks a revised version and explains a remaining limitation.

Defence and delivery

Beginning: Required files are missing or the student cannot locate relevant decisions.

Developing: Some files and explanations are usable; delivery checks or reasoning are incomplete.

Secure: PSD, checked export, plan and source log are usable; the student defends three choices and handles a taught change.

Extending: A concise evidence-based defence explains trade-offs and independently verified changes; the handoff is clear and reliable.